household, tears and scolding; men for higher education and women for primary education only; women as a burden and men as progenitors of the lineage; women for sacrifice and men for adventure; men as providers and policy-makers and women as acquirers of gold and jewellery. She did not have to go to school or college to learn these facts because they were evident in her own home, the joint family of the Peshawarias. Her grandfather was the typical autocrat whose authority was final and her grandmother the typical collector of gold ornaments and other jewellery. And this state of affairs was comfortably accepted by the younger generation of Peshawarias. The only exceptions to the rule were Kiran's parents. They had four daughters and no son, and were determined to ensure that all their daughters grew up to be exceptionally self-reliant. Her grandfather and uncles, however, showed great concern for Kiran's father for having four daughters, who, in their mind, were expected to be 'burdens'. As a matter of fact, her grandmother would suggest to her sons that since Parkash had four 'liabilities', he should be adequately compensated for by giving him a larger portion of the properties as and when they would be divided. In other words, she was ensuring that sufficient dowry was available so that her grand-daughters could get decent husbands.

Kiran's parents, however, never looked upon their daughters this way. They provided their offspring with maximum opportunities for the best education, for the best sports facilities and for all possible creative activities so that they emerged self-assured, self-confident and self-dependent. They were never looked upon as girls for whom husbands had to be found, but always as children who would grow up and carve out careers for themselves. Her father would often explain to them how Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru had always urged women to come forward and how he envisaged the role of women in the future of India. And Kiran's mother would warn her daughters about the dangers of depending on others. 'Self-reliance' was her 'mantra for life', which she instilled in all her children and Kiran followed this mantra as the gospel truth.

Kiran has always treasured every word spoken or written by her father and mother. Such words remain her most precious possessions, which were a lifeline that kept the positive energy flowing. Here is one such 'gem' from her treasures, which needs to be recorded for posterity: